

ILLUSTRATION

Overview

Illustration transforms ideas into visual stories that speak across all languages and cultures. Illustration majors learn to bring complex concepts to life—educating, clarifying, and making the abstract tangible. This work bridges the gap between words and understanding, whether illuminating design processes, bringing fictional worlds to vivid life, or motivating people to solve real-world problems.

Illustration is both mirror and window: it reflects reality while opening portals to impossible worlds. Through compelling imagery, illustrators spark empathy, ignite imagination, and turn passive viewers into engaged participants.

Illustrators are visual problem-solvers and storytellers—translating clients' visions into powerful imagery that resonates, persuades, and endures. Whether collaborating in creative teams or working independently, illustrators develop a unique professional capacity: **they are translators of the visual world—turning concepts into connections that resonate across audiences and industries.**

Banner Image Credit: Maddie Lickteig

B.F.A. in Illustration degree requirements

The curriculum leads to a 128-credit undergraduate Bachelor of Fine Arts in Illustration. Admission into the program requires the completion of at least 31.0 credits, including the following courses: DSNS 1020, DSNS 1100 or 115, DSNS 1310, DSNS 1320, and DSNS 1830 (13 credits); 6 credits of Social Sciences/Humanities; 6 credits of Math/Science; ENGL 1500 (or test-out credit); LIB 1600. Information on admission criteria is posted each year on the College of Design website.

Required Courses: (58 credits)

Design Core (13 credits):

DSN S 1020: Design Studio I (4 credits)

DSN S 1310: Drawing 1 (4 credits)

DSN S 1830: Design in Context (3 credits)

DSNS 1320: Digital Design Literacy (1 credit)

DSNS 1100: Design Exchange Seminar I or 1150: Design Collaborative Seminar (1 credit)

Art History & Criticism (12 credits):

ARTH 2800: History of Art I (3 credits)

ARTH 2810: History of Art II (3 credits)

ARTH 3000/4000: Elective (3 credits)

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Drawing Core (12 credits):

ART 2300: Drawing II (3 credits)

ART 4300: Advanced Drawing (3 credits)

ART 4320: Sequential Narrative Drawing (3 credits)

ART 4310: Character and Scene Design (3 credits)

Illustration Studio Core (12 credits):

ILLUS 2400: Survey of Illustration I (3 credits) – studio

ILLUS 2410: Survey of Illustration II (3 credits) – studio

ILLUS 3400: Concept and Ideation I (3 credits)

ILLUS 3410: Concept and Ideation II (3 credits)

Illustration Capstone (9 credits):

ART 3990: Professional Practice (2 credits)

ART 4990: BFA Exhibition (1 credit)

ILLUS 4400: Illustration Senior Thesis I – Portfolio (3 credits)

ILLUS 4410: Illustration Senior Thesis II – Business Practices and Industry Standards (3 credits)

Studio Options: Students choose 27 credits from the following courses

Drawing:

ART 3230/SciVZ: Scientific Illustration Principles and Techniques (3 credits)

ART 3260: Digital Rendering (3 credits)

ART 3270/SciVZ: Illustration as Communication (3 credits)

ART 3300: Life Drawing (3 credits)

ART 3370/SciVZ: Application of Scientific Illustration Techniques (3 credits)

Painting:

ART 2130: Studio Fundamentals: Painting (2 credits)

ART 2380: Painting I (3 credits) – Rome Option only

ART 2330: Watercolor Painting (3 credits)

ART 3380: Painting II (3 credits)

ART 4380: Painting III (3 credits)

Photography:

ART 2100: Studio Fundamentals: Photo (2 credits)

ART 3290: Creative Photography (3 credits)

ART 4290: Advanced Photography (3 credits)

Printmaking:

ART 2060: Studio Fundamentals: Printmaking (2 credits)

ART 3560: Relief Printmaking: Digital/Traditional (3 credits)

ART 3570: Intaglio and Monotype Printmaking: Digital / Traditional (3 credits)

ART 3580: Lithography: Digital / Traditional (3 credits)

ART 3590: Screen-printing (3 credits)

Digital imaging and animation:

ART 2120: Studio Fundamentals: Digital Media (3 credits)

ART 4700: Data, Code, and Form (3 credits)

ART 4070: Principles of Character Animation (3 credits)

ART 4080: Principles of 3D Animation (3 credits)

Graphic Design:

ARTGR 4840A: Illustration in Graphic Design (3 credits)

ARTGR 4840B: Lettering in Graphic Design (3 credits)

The remaining 43 credits follow University and College of Design requirements:

International Perspective: 3 credits

U.S. Cultures and Communities (Formerly U.S. Diversity): 3 credits

Communication: 10 credits

Humanities: 6 credits from College of Design General Education

Approved Course list

Social Sciences: 6 credits from College of Design General Education

Approved Course list

Math/Physics/Biological Sciences: 6 credits from College of Design

General Education Approved Course list

General Education Courses: 9 credits (6 credits at level 3000-4000 from College of Design General Education Approved Course List; 3 credits from College of Design General Education Approved Course list)

B.F.A. in Illustration Four Year Plan

First Year

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
DSNS 1020 or 1310	4 DSNS 1020 or 1310	4
DSNS 1100 or 1150	1 DSNS 1830 (or General Education)	3
DSNS 1320	1 ENGL 1500 (or General Education)	3
DSNS 1830 (or General Education)	3 General Education	3
ENGL 1500 (or General Education)	3 General Education	3
General Education	3 LIB 1600	1
General Education	3	
	18	17

Second Year

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
ARTH 2800	3 ARTH 2810	3
ILLUS 2400 Survey of Illustration I	3 ILLUS 2410 Survey of Illustration II	3
ART 2300 (or Studio Option) Studio Option	3 ART 2300 (or Studio Option) 3 General Education	3
General Education	3 Studio Option	3
ENGL 2500 (or General Education)	3 ENGL 2500 (or General Education)	3
	18	18

Third Year

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
ILLUS 3400 Concept and Ideation I	3 ILLUS 3410 Concept and Ideation II	3
ART 4300 (or Studio Option) Studio Option	3 ART 4300 (or Studio Option) 3 Studio Option	3
ARTH 3000 level or above	3 ARTH 3000 level or above	3
General Education	3 ART 3990	2
	15	14

Fourth Year

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
ILLUS 4400 Illustration Senior Thesis I – Portfolio	3 ILLUS 4410 Illustration Senior Thesis II – Business Practices and Industry Standards	3
ART 4300 (or Studio Option)	3 ART 4300 (or Studio Option)	3
ART 4310	3 ART 4320	3
Studio Option	3 ART 4990	1
General Education	3 General Education	3
	15	13